Columbia University: Arts & Sciences
A&S Spring 2026 Standard Evaluation

Course: EEEBUN3320_001_2026_1 - Biological Interactions in a Changing Wo: EEEBW3320_001_2026_1_234514

Instructor: Rachel Cohen *

Response Rate: 5/5 (100.00 %)

1 - What did you learn - in terms of knowledge, skills, or perspectives - in this course?The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Rate	3/5 (60%)

- Conditions, consequences, and examples of coevolution; how to write a grant proposal
- I learned a lot about biological interactions. It is very broad, but we do enough examples and case studies to feel like I am actually learning about these types of interactions. In terms of skills, I learned a lot about how to better read and discuss challenging scientific not in my field (via the case studies) and how to write a grant proposal and design a research study. In terms of perspectives, I really liked the chapters from Braiding Sweetgrass, and it and the course taught me more about how we should appreciate that nature provides us with knowledge.
- I learned a lot about interspecies interactions and the processes that enable them. The course was more evolution-based than ecology-based, which I wasn't expecting, but I still enjoyed it

2 - What percentage of the work (including reading) assigned for this course did you complete on schedule?

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
All or almost all	(1)	1	20.00%		
Most	(2)	3	60.00%		
Some	(3)	1	20.00%		
This question is not applicable	(4)	0	0.00%		

0 25 50 100

Response Rate
5/5 (100.00%)

3 - What is your overall assessment of the course? What are its strengths? In what ways might it be improved? In answering this question, you might address the value of readings and assignments, the structure of the course (including the relationship of sections to lectures), the contribution of the course to your knowledge of the subject matter and to the development of your analytical and reasoning skills, etc. We encourage you to use specific examples where possible.

Response Rate	4/5 (80%)

- Strengths - breadth and depth of knowledge, development of analysis skills of primary literature Improvements - mechanics of course organization, tying everything together, through-line of all the discrete ideas we have encountered
- This course could be improved by dropping some of the readings (which didn't always feel super helpful) or making them optional for students to read when they felt confused by lecture and wanted to dive deeper into a concept. I would not say this is the case for all of our readings, just some. I also did not like the pop-science readings/videos/podcasts. They usually felt like a repetition of something we were reading in a paper, but just at a lower level. They could maybe be optional for students who were confused and wanted to have a higher-level summary to better understand the scientific publication. I think the mandatory case studies were good though, and should definitely stay. The project and quizzes were fair and reflected the content taught in class.
- I think the course was structured well and the lectures felt well-paced. The readings could occasionally be dry, but were always relevant to that week's topic. I think the final assignment and non-cumulative tests were also well-paced.
- Dr. Cohen has structured the course that follows a logical progression of basic theory to more complex systems of interactions, moving from broad scale species interactions toward the nuances within science and even theories that are being questioned today. Tuesdays are lecture, while Thursdays are case-study reviews that were assigned for the week. The syllabus is very true to the expectations in the course. Readings may be challenging without a prior background in ecology (at least Life Systems course would be useful before the class). However, Dr. Cohen is incredibly skilled at explaining complex theory, methodology, and ecology at various scales.

4 - What is your overall assessment of the course?The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
Excellent	(5)	4	80.00%		4.80
Very Good	(4)	1	20.00%		
Good	(3)	0	0.00%		
Fair	(2)	0	0.00%		
Poor	(1)	0	0.00%		

0 25 50 100 Question

Response Rate	Mean	STD	Median
5/5 (100.00%)	4.80	0.45	5.00

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5 - Would you recommend this course to another student?The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
Definitely recommend	(1)	2	40.00%		
Probably recommend	(2)	3	60.00%		
I'm not sure I'd recommend	(3)	0	0.00%		
Probably not recommend	(4)	0	0.00%		
Definitely not recommend	(5)	0	0.00%		

0 25 50 100

Response Rate
5/5 (100.00%)

6 - Please qualify your recommendations if you wish:The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Rate	2/5 (40%)

- Recommend if you have TIME to develop a brand new primary research proposal. The course is effectively 4 to 5 credits worth of work
- Incredibly thorough in laying the foundations for understanding both basic and complex systems of ecological interactions, from broad to micro-scale systems.

7 - How does the workload in this course compare to Columbia courses with a similar structure (e.g. a lecture, seminar, laboratory, or language course)?The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
Much heavier workload	(1)	1	20.00%		
Heavier workload	(2)	1	20.00%		
Similar workload	(3)	3	60.00%		
Lighter workload	(4)	0	0.00%		
Much lighter workload	(5)	0	0.00%		
No basis for comparison	(6)	0	0.00%		

0 25 50 100

Response Rate
5/5 (100.00%)

8 - How many hours a week did you devote to this course? (Note: Please include all time spent on this class including class time, discussion sections, readings, assignments, studying, etc.)The answer to this question will generally be available in Vergil.

Response Rate	3/5 (60%)

- 15
- 6-10, depending on if we had an assignment that week
- 6-9 Hours per week

9 - Please evaluate Rachel Cohen. What are Rachel Cohen's strengths? In what ways might their teaching be improved? In answering this question, you might address the clarity of the lectures or presentations and their relationship to the other elements of the course, the ability of Rachel Cohen to generate enthusiasm and facilitate discussion, the quality of feedback, availability, the timeliness of the return assignment, etc. -

Response Rate	3/5 (60%)

- Strengths - generating enthusiasm, breaking down complex concepts into simple-to-understand examples, periodic checking-in on student understanding, adaptive to student feedback, high-quality detailed feedback on assignments, ample suggestions for research directions Improvements - could make clearer how concepts build upon each other in the course
- Rachel is a great instructor. She is very clear when she lectures (and corrects herself if she feels she was unclear) and is able to lead great discussions. She can also answer complicated or niche questions generally on the spot, and will be clear when she is unable to answer the question. She is timely with email responses and grading and had ample opportunities for us to go to office hours. The only thing is the slides are very wordy and go by quickly, and she lectures saying a lot of the same things that are written on the slides. I think she could benefit by having emptier slides and elaborating on what she says without having it written. It makes it a bit difficult to take notes at times, and I rely on taking notes for memory and learning purposes. Rachel also did a great job of adjusting the course from feedback from the mid-semester review, and things felt a bit smoother after that since there were previously some hiccups.
- Dr. Cohen was by far one of the most thoughtful, critical, and communicative lecturers throughout the STEM courses I've taken at Columbia. I came into the course with little coursework on ecology, with more geoscience knowledge, and was nervous about how well I'd be able to succeed. However, the way Dr. Cohen structured the course, coupled with her lecturing style, always left me more confident leaving the classroom than when I first came in. Not only have I now been exposed to theory, methodology, and material on broad ecological interactions, I now have an ability to read complex research papers and comprehend them on a level unknown to me before. Additionally, she took the time to integrate computational components, data analyses, and novel ideas in the classroom, which shows that the field is not stagnant but constantly developing in our changing world. I leave this class with greater confidence because of Dr. Cohen. Not only does she have a deep understanding of the field and its nuances, she can articulately explain them at varying levels of knowledge. As a lecturer, she takes the time to make sure you understand the material, not by simply giving you an answer but by guiding your reasoning and logic through recalling lecture and reading materials, allowing you to develop your own answer. Moreover, Dr. Cohen's lecture style allows the class to naturally drift toward open discussion when needed, providing a space to bounce ideas around the classroom or share our own interpretations together. This was a critical part in structuring my understanding of the material. During office hours, she has taken the time to support me in my academic journey, proving feedback on our class research grant proposal project on top of graduate school admissions advice. In summary, Dr. Cohen's passion, enthusiasm, and knowledge has been a guiding force in my last semester as a student. I never would have believed I'd understand molecular phylogenetics by the end of this semester. Yet, here I am, confidently navigating complex research papers on biological interactions.

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10 - What is the overall teaching effectiveness of Rachel Cohen? -

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
Excellent	(5)	5	100.00%		5.00
Very Good	(4)	0	0.00%		
Good	(3)	0	0.00%		
Fair	(2)	0	0.00%		
Poor	(1)	0	0.00%		
				0 25 50 100	Question

Response Rate	Mean	STD	Median
5/5 (100.00%)	5.00	0.00	5.00

11 - What are the strengths and weaknesses of (discussion section leader, lab section leader, grader) as an instructor, and how might 's teaching be improved?

Response Rate	0/5 (0%)

12 - What is the overall teaching effectiveness of ?

Response Option	Weight	Frequency	Percent	Percent Responses	Means
Excellent	(5)	0	0.00%		
Very Good	(4)	0	0.00%		
Good	(3)	0	0.00%		
Fair	(2)	0	0.00%		
Poor	(1)	0	0.00%		0.00
				0 25 50 100	Question

Response Rate	Mean	STD	Median
0/5 (0.00%)	0.00	0.00	0.00